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Croatia Immigration/Emigration

Croatia, a country located in the Balkans, current NATO member since 2009, and recent member of EU in 2013, is facing a lot of issues when it comes to immigration and migrations. Main concerns are when refugees come to the border, asylum seeking, and experiencing the increase in emigration, happening more than immigration. There has been a migrant crisis going on forever. Lately, we've been falsely accused by the media for committing human rights abuses at the border. Especially, false accusation of police abuse and torture of migrants and asylum-seekers coming from mainly Bosnia and Herzegovina. In addition, there has been false accusations and exaggerations by the media even, that we are illegally pushing refugees back.^[1] The main reason we are one of the few countries in the EU being falsely attacked like this is because our border mechanisms are mismanaged and we don't have as many or adequate asylums for the incoming refugees. That's why we're having trouble making them stay or keeping them safe. Yet we require further support from the EU in helping us with our border system and asylum processing if we want to improve. Moreover, when it comes to migration, from 2015 to 2021 so far, the population of Croatia decreased by 4.26 inhabitants per 1,000 citizens only due to the Croatian emigration rate, which happens to be the second largest decline through migration in the European Union.^[2] We tend to be one of the only five countries in the EU to face more emigration than immigration. As we figured, a survey from 2009 found that 65% of our citizens decide to emigrate from here due to poor socioeconomic development and 53% said it was due to corruption. In addition, there has been complaints about us not being so efficient in improving areas of healthcare, education, research, and development, which makes certain people unsatisfied with moving or staying in this country, lagging behind other EU countries.^[3] Therefore, we also ask for further support from the EU to help with improving our health, economic, research, education opportunities and dealt with any corruption our country could be going through.

Priorities

Croatia is working on trying to improve its border mechanisms at all costs, trying to make it more efficient, more transparent, and better at investigating any human rights abuses that could occur. In addition, it is working on improving its asylum system, by expanding it, make it more efficient and valuable for migrants. Also, when it comes to emigration, Croatia is working its hardest to speed up reforms and growth in our economy, basic needs like education and healthcare, invest more in research and development, dealing with corruption, in order to be as good as other countries in the EU. If we meet these goals, we will not have to face false accusations about our treatment of migrants, we will have more spots for refugees, and if we improve our socioeconomic status, be as good as other members of the EU, this will encourage more people to stay here or even immigrate here if they want to find a job and have a good standards of living.

Current Status

Currently, in order to deal with the migrant crisis at the border, lacking our border mechanisms, Croatia has so far announced a new border monitoring mechanism, in order to provide for independent human rights monitoring of border operations and we're making sure to make it meet the standards needed to make it effective and successful. The mechanism is supposed to be independent in law, practices, have sufficient sources, and a robust mandate in order to be successful in monitoring operations around the state at the border.^[4] This should be able to investigate and find any human rights violations we committed at the border, but we have to see if the European Union agrees to this mechanism. Furthermore, as of now, under EU's Asylum Migration and International Fund (AMIF), Croatia receives about €108 million. In addition, it's received €23.3 million in emergency assistance for migration and border management since 2017.^[5] Moreover, in order for improvements in socioeconomic development so less people decide to emigrate from here, we have taken large steps to improve it research and development by signing an advisory agreement where the World Bank will deliver technical assistance to support our Government improving efficiency and capacity for implementation of research and innovation policies.^[6] Also, recently Croatia has signed several acts against corruption such as the Corporate Criminal Liability Act, the Conflict-of-Interest Prevention Act, the Money Laundering and Terrorist Financing Act, the Civil Servants Act, the Code of Conduct for Public Officials, and the Code of Judicial Ethics, all which will deal with any corruption we face with our judicial system, public services like healthcare and education, and so on.^[7]

Policy Options

- a) Ask the EU's Asylum Migration and International Fund (AMIF) to provide twice the amount of funds, to increase support for early integration and dealing with any accusations that happen at our border and increase the funds we receive from the European Social Fund Plus (ESF+) to increase support for median and long-term integration (The European Union might believe it's a waste of money and not accept it. However, if we receive more funds, there will be a lot less accusations made about our police force's treatment of migrants and asylum-seekers and their returns. In addition, an increase in ESF+ would encourage more people to immigrate here or stay).
- b) Make a treaty with several other EU members and the commission that will improve our border mechanisms (Even though there is a migrant crisis going on, the problems happening at certain countries borders might not be the same and it would be hard to negotiate it. However, it's a great way we could put an end to the migrant crisis if we came together).
- c) Make an agreement with other EU leaders to increase Anti-Corruption measures that go after abuses of power that could be happening with our migration system and others (Not all countries might agree to this since it might hurt their sovereignty and such. However, if we all agree to increasing any anti-corruption measures possible, the problems at the border or local factors at home that could be driving away citizens could be dealt with faster and be cleaned up quicker).

Policy Recommendation

The Foreign Ministry of Croatia recommends policy option a) ‘Ask the EU’s Asylum Migration and International Fund (AMIF) to provide twice the amount of funds and increase European Social Fund Plus (ESF+)’. We feel that if we receive twice the amount of funds from the AMIF, it will increase the development of legal migration along with Croatia’s economic and social needs. More funds would strongly tackle any irregular border policies and human rights abuses that could be occurring at the border. Also, more funds would be helpful in expanding and improving the size and stability of our current asylums which look outdated to compare other EU countries’ asylums. This would keep us safer, help with our border transparency, and treatment of any migrants that come here, putting an end to our migrant crisis. Moreover, more funds from the ESF+, which are funds also coming from the Youth Employment Initiative (YEI), Funds for European Union and to the Most Deprived (FEAD), Employment and Social Innovation (EASI), and EU Health Program, would tackle all the barriers our institutions are facing that are making people emigrate out of our country. It would strengthen and help healthcare and education be more efficient and accessible to the people. In addition, it would make our country far more innovative and offer more job opportunities, make us reach the same level of socioeconomic development as other EU countries. Although it might be too much money, this would help Croatia be a safer country for asylum-seekers and more developed country for people living here.

Budget

Currently, the budget from 2021-2027 of the AMIF is €9.9 billion and Croatia has been receiving a small amount of €108 million.^[5] We would encourage the AMIF to increase that amount to about €216 million. On the other hand, the ESF+ total budget is €99.3 billion from 2021-2027 and Croatia has only received €110 million.^[8] We would rather have the ESF+ increase that amount to €200 million.

EU’s Asylum Migration and International Fund (AMIF) 9.9 billion will promote the efficient management of migration flows and the implementation, strengthening and development of a common European Union approach to asylum and immigration.

promoting high employment levels, building social protection and developing a skilled and resilient workforce ready for the transition to a green and digital economy.

Source:

<https://www.theguardian.com/global-development/2020/jun/15/eu-covered-up-croatias-failure-to-protect-migrants-from-border-brutality> [1]

<https://www.total-croatia-news.com/politics/50555-croatian-emigration-rate> [2]

https://www.sgi-network.org/2020/Croatia/Key_Challenges [3]

<https://www.hrw.org/news/2021/08/02/croatia/eu-strengthen-border-monitoring-system#> [4]

<https://www.amnesty.org/en/latest/press-release/2020/11/eu-inquiry-into-european-complicity-in-croatian-border-violence-against-migrants-and-refugees-significant/> [5]

<https://www.worldbank.org/en/news/press-release/2021/09/30/world-bank-supports-croatia-in-improving-effectiveness-of-investments-in-research-development-and-innovation> [6]

<https://www.ganintegrity.com/portal/country-profiles/croatia/> [7]

https://ec.europa.eu/esf/main.jsp?catId=67&langId=en&newsId=9890&utm_campaign=58ca6a2173a6a3222e01b7f2&utm_content=600ecf3821a57e0001419c21&utm_medium=smarpshare&utm_source=generic [8]